

Heart of EMPTINESS

A collection of short stories that capture the alienation of modern city life

By Geeta Doctor



It probably helps if you are young, restless and filled with testosterone-fuelled rage, as the male protagonists of Palash Krishna Mehrotra in this collection of short stories tend to be. He shores up the unrequited lust of every schoolboy's blues and spills it into terse tales of failed encounters between men and women. This is the heart of emptiness that has followed the promise of India's *vroom-vroom* generation into fiction made fashionable by members of a new elite, who appear to be striking at the soft underbelly of a corrupt society while wallowing in it themselves.

Mehrotra displays a crotch consciousness that might have been beguiling in the way an earlier generation of writers like Shashti Brata managed except that he inhabits an altogether narrower world. His best stories have the hyena-like quality of boys living together in packs. He displays the tense loathing for authority that one might find in that ancient cult drama, "The loneliness of the Long-Distance Runner", without the rage that made it so memorable.

Like the two young men, Feroz and Pradeep—maybe we should label them 'boys'—in *Freshers*

Welcome, a story about the rituals of initiation and acceptance, also known as ragging, it's the narrowness of the bed that they share in their hostel room that turns them into partners. Pradeep, the younger boy, is entirely a passive and even acquiescent victim. Let it also be said that by turning the pencil torchlight of his character, Pradeep's recollections into the peculiar nature of these male bondings that will continue to survive despite all parental warnings and editorial anguish attempting to ban the activity, Mehrotra seems to suggest that there is nothing unnatural about ragging. By cutting through the moral debates, he works like a surgeon who has been asked to lay open the viscera of a TB patient suffering from an intestinal infestation and allow light to invade the area with the prospect of healing.

This may be the best way to view the collection's twitchy tales from here and there. He brings a healing touch. There is an interesting enough range of characters who roam around from New Delhi to Bombay, (that's the way it continues to be spelt here): Anmol, the protagonist of the title story who desperately wants to follow the hostel regulations on celibacy while satisfying the needs of the young woman he is courting; Alok, the Gujarati son and husband who takes mangoes to his parental home; and "Helicopter" Sunil Singh, the teacher with the unrequited passion for a lady teacher that fuels him into a rage of frenzied canings against the boys in his class. Mehrotra details the lashes with a precision that can only come from personal observation. There is also a certain sameness about them. The characters morph into each other with a monotonous gravitas that can be perversely compelling. We are expected to enjoy their humiliation, the taste of blood in the mouth of Angad, "the middle level techie in a sinking dot.com" as he lies on a road off "Okhla Basti" waiting for the feral dogs to close in. Is this, because like the author, we can't really care much for these people, the sad doggy men and frisky girls he has culled for our entertainment?

One has only to think of a Haruki Murakami and look for a comparison. Murakami also details the alienation of modern city life on the lives of his characters but he does so with a passion that allows them the possibility of escape. There is no comparison.



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